deadline… I can’t understand a search committee spending 15 months on a search.’

According to Nohria, by mid-2014, the lacklustre performance of the group under its new chairman became a matter of increasing concern. Both Ratan and Nohria took stock of the situation and the options that they had before them. They decided that it would be prudent to give Mistry more support and encouragement. Both agreed that Ratan and the board should assume this role. The duo was ‘hoping and praying and trying hard to see if with encouragement’ Mistry would measure up to his onerous responsibilities, recalls Nohria. To accomplish it, ‘we would have done whatever we could to make him successful’, he remarks.

He elaborates that Mistry grossly failed to make use of Ratan’s vast experience. This was surprising as Mistry had himself acknowledged the entrepreneurial achievements of his predecessor. In his note of October 2010 that he sent to the selection committee, he had stated, ‘Today the Entrepreneurship comes from Mr Ratan Tata.’ But after becoming the chairman, he did not set much store by the recommendation and the assertions he made both as a member of the selection committee and later as a candidate.

In view of the issue of conflict of interest and Mistry’s lacklustre performance, replacing him was one of the alternatives discussed. But it was not a serious thought at this point. They did not want to take any decision until Mistry had had more time to settle down to assess his strength as a leader worthy of steering the largest conglomerate of the country, Nohria says.

But Mistry’s performance did not show any remarkable change. Even two years after Nohria and Ratan discussed the wisdom of continuing with Mistry at the helm, there didn’t seem to be much improvement. During the period 2013–14 to 2016–17 (when Mistry was at the helm) the annual average growth rate (AAGR) in the revenue of the group was 1.04 per cent. In comparison, during Ratan’s time at the helm (1991–92 to 2012–13), it was 17.13 per cent. By April 2016, Ratan had lost hope of Mistry growing in his job and was inclined to look for a replacement. Venu Srinivasan adds that it ‘was clear that there had to be a change of guard’ and they needed at the apex, ‘somebody who will actually set those problems right’. He adds that Ratan was nearing eighty years of age and he ‘wanted to make sure that the group would be left in safe hands’, and if ‘another five years went by,